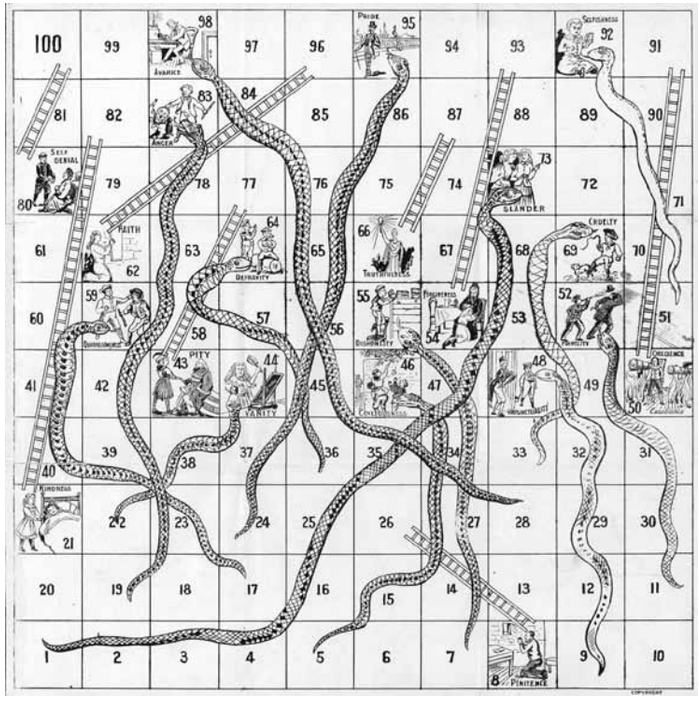


A topological hymn to the abyss: The schematic map of the modern abyss[1]—namely, the post-Copernican account of nature—can be geometrically laid out as the simple board game *Snakes and Ladders*:

Snake — Just as the ladder of nature (*scala naturae*) was finally toppled;

Ladder — And the serpent of genesis responsible for the descent of Man from heavens to the Earth appeared to be a rope unanchored and loose at both ends, bearing the gnaw marks of Copernicus, Darwin and Freud;

Snake — So must the classic board game undergo some changes, its moral message erased, its geometry modernized and its players renegotiated.

Snake — In favor of "cutting loose the natural history of mankind from the Bible"[2];

Ladder — And flushing out and away the patent symbolism of Snakes and Ladders;

Snake and Ladder — *We modernize the ludic interface of the game.*

Snake — It is imperative to rediscover the figure of the player;

Ladder — And its voice, its status and its expression;

Snake and Ladder — *Strictly according to modern geometric schemata of the game.*

Ladder — If the modern and scientifically disenthralled image of Man is a transitive local reflection of the abyss;

Snake — And the player also reflects the rules, interfaces, implicit properties and the overall dynamics of the game;

Snake and Ladder — *Then, we can say that not only the new game must reflect in its players as its own local dynamic profiles but also, the player must be entirely perceived in terms of the self-reflective world of the game.*

Ladder — Since Snakes and Ladders is a geometric schema of the abyss;

Snakes — Then the evolution of Man as a potential player of this game must be thought not in terms of:

Ladder — Ascending a transcendentally-bound lattice

Snake — Or descending from a transcendentally-positioned firmament

Snake and Ladder — *But in terms of staring back into the modern abyss from a geo metrical point of view. That is to say, from our point of view in the absence of any lattice to which we can be bound.*

Snake — Our view;

Ladder — That is a geometrical point of view;

Snake — Is constituted of a general space where properties of the abyss are expressed in terms of all manners of transit;

Ladder — Change of base and transfer of structure;

Snake — Alternative passages and tones;

Ladder — Pointers and Arrows;

Snake — Suspended ladders;

Ladder — And disenchanted snakes.

1 "[An] opening in which everything is gulped down, the Abyss refuses to hold anything grounded" (Martin Heidegger) "because it is in itself absolved from all [transcendental] bounds" (Gabriel Catren) and regional obstructions by which its experience or its absolute relation to itself can be privatized in the name of man, earth or matter. It is an immanently public outdoor where expropriation without compensation is the law.

2 Josiah Clark Nott, Two Lectures on the Connection between the Biblical and Physical History of Man.

Snakes and Ladder — *All brought about by the continuous and unbound relation of the abyss/nature to itself.*

We call this modern player that reflects the geometric schema of the abyss in the ostensibly distinct voice of Man in nature and re-navigates the local horizon of Man and its voice in terms of a geometric perspective into the abyss, chimera.

Snake — As that which belongs,
Ladder — To no "personal suppositio",
Snake — "chimera is a man" (◊¬p),
Ladder — And "chimera is not a man" (◊p),
Snake and Ladder — *At the same time*.[3]

(It is a non-local profile of the modern abyss's unbound relation to itself—a 'geometrical germ' from which various procedures of chimerization (musico-acoustical, philosophical, ludological, …) and teratomodal ramifications can grow and pullulate.)

THE SNAKE, THE GOAT AND THE LADDER
(A board game for playing chimera)

HOW TO START THE GAME

"The zero is an eternal act. [And] the eternal is the nothing of nature [which is] not an absolute nothing [but] an act devoid of substratum."[4] The game begins with navigation from 0 qua the indivisible nature as the first act—an act without substratum. It consists of 'being posited' according to the contingency of the eternal, or an introverted universal dice.

PLATFORM AND INTERFACES

Chimera's den—the board—is a rubber sheet. Its geometry is that of the geometry of a rubber sheet capable of bending, twisting and continuous transformation or deformation without its essential properties being changed or disturbed. Upon entering chimera's den, an inscription reads: Adopt "topological reasoning"[5], all you who enter here.

The modernly customized platform of Snakes and Ladders is a topological space. It is identified by its profound continuity and its protean relation to itself. Within this topological space, no local relation, no discrete entity, point, concept, individual or player can retain its identity without a recursive descent into the proto-relation—that is to say, the continuity—of the space to itself.

Whereas in the pre-modern version of Snakes and Ladders, the stepwise distribution of numbered or axiomatized cells determined the navigational space of the player, in its new form the distribution of axiomatic cells and numbers is on the basis of topological permissibility and the relation or continuity of the space to itself that precedes axioms and numbers.

The chimeric landscape of the topological gamespace can no longer be mapped on to a grid. Rather than transcendentally and axiomatically bound cells through which the player (i.e. a particular profile of the gamespace itself) ascends or descends, the chimeric landscape is comprised of topological neighborhoods, or:

3 William of Ockham, Philosophical writings: a selection.
4 Lorenz Oken, Elements of Physiophilosophy.
5 Guerino Mazzola, The Topos of Music: Geometric Logic of Concepts, Theory, and Performance.

– Modes of environments of the abyss/real which osmotically pass the self-relationship of nature.
– Fuzzy sites surrounding actual marks where synthetically-potent and fusible points—infinitesimal deformation points or fleeting possibilia—are accumulated.
– Local profiles of the gamespace (i.e. players) which are interwoven together by means of the continuity or the universal relation of the gamespace to itself.

Chimera's Lemma: Unlike the latticed terrain of Snakes and Ladders where navigation (ascension and descent) is predicated upon the correlation between axiomatically bound regions of space and statistical probability implicated in the dice throw, the chimeric landscape loosens the lattice and opens up counterintuitive transit passages through and between topological neighborhoods or environments of the real, giving rise to chimera as its projection:

(*proof of the lemma*)

● Following any navigational path in the chimeric landscape entails passing through the landscape's topological neighborhoods where possibilia and deformation points can fuse, merge, shift, intermix through various local surgery methods (embedding, immersion, transplantation, …) and thus bringing about all manners of continuous deformation, twisting, contamination and non-trivial combinatorial passages between neighborhoods or different local profiles of the gamespace/abyss.

○ As the non-essential/expendable player G follows a particular path/address (@) on the chimeric landscape of the topological gamespace, its navigational approach to the gamespace or the modern abyss can be formalized as G∘@ (G *composed with* @).

◌ Since G∘@ is a given concrete composition within the chimeric landscape which is comprised of different local profiles or topological neighborhoods of the gamespace and since these neighborhoods can be counterintuitively deformed, decomposed, twisted, transplanted and immersed into and within one another, then G∘@ must be defined in terms of alternative passages between various topological neighborhoods or compositions.

By traversing a particular path, the expendable player G becomes a concrete composition over the chimeric landscape. The concrete composition G∘@—or less formally, Goat (G∘At)—can be produced by different commutative passages composed of local profiles of the gamespace (i.e. players or objects) and alternative paths (morphisms, or abstract snakes and ladders) opened up and potentiated by the fusions and transplantations of topological neighborhoods. In other words, Goat becomes a concrete composition for all manners of topological deformation from one structure to another, cobordisms or shared boundaries between heterogeneous manifolds, teratomodal surgeries between actuality, possibility and generality, non-trivial passages, fusions of incommensurabilities and transgender syntheses.

Once the goat gazed into the vast unbroken blue pasture, it beheld a modal monster—no longer a mere impossibility—engendered by "invariants beyond the flux of transformations"[6] and twisted by countless non-trivial passages each "carrying its space with it like a snail carries its shell".[7] A voice rang in its ears, "For if you attempt [seeking chimera], nature will assist you, and make good your endeavours, and the work will much delight you: for you shall see such things effected, as you would not think of."[8] All of a sudden, the descent into the abyss became irresistible. Chimera then understood that it was true after all that from a geometric point of view, the abyss cannot tell the difference between a goat, a lioness and a disenchanted snake.

(A historical digression: It is said that the mythological chimera, the she-goat of Lycia, was an offspring of Echidna and Typhon who had combined, in the most eccentric manner, three distinct composites within itself. Rather than being a monster by the virtue of being "a hybrid of different body parts"[9], it was a global composition of three particular composites—a goat, a lioness and a snake each carrying its own respective space within the beast. Chimera was accordingly considered a non-monster that posed a threat to the metric reasoning of the composer in the clothing of a teratologist. For the priest in the clothing of a logician, on the other hand, chimera was a relational and modal conundrum for it bore a series of relationships between different heterogeneous or incommensurable objects (or particular compositions such as G∘@) which appeared impossible insofar as the discrete modality of each animal was intruded by the multi-modal continuity of chimera.[10] But above all, the compositional eccentricity of chimera sublimated in its voice, a synthesis between the voiceless alveolar 'hissing' sibilants of its mother—the she-viper Echidna—and the plosive oppression of its father typhoon. Chimera's voice was a composition of various animal vocalizations glued together according to their internal consistencies, continuities between manners of articulation, their relations to their ambient space and various swaps and transfers between them—a universal composition at the same time irreducible to discrete voices and transcending their cacophonic conjunction.)

THE CHIMERIC PLAYER

Chimera is a post-pandemonic composition. Rather than purely conforming to the transformational and compositional paradigm of metric reasoning, chimera is produced according to a topological paradigm where the composition is "somewhere in the middle between intractable monsters and insignificant atomized data"[11], the trivial combination of discrete voices and non-local continuities capable of unfurling counter-intuitive variations of each and every voice.

6 Fernando Zalamea, Peirce and Latin American "Razonabilidad": Forerunners of Transmodernity.
7 Guerino Mazzola, The Topos of Music: Geometric Logic of Concepts, Theory, and Performance.
8 Giambattista della Porta, Natural Magick.
9 Ambroise Paré, Des Monstres
10 See John Buridan, John Buridan on Self-Reference: Chapter Eight of Buridan's Sophismata.
11 Guerino Mazzola, The Topos of Music: Geometric Logic of Concepts, Theory, and Performance.

Chimera is simply the reflection of G∘@ in the protean continuity of nature or the unbound relation of the abyss to itself. This reflection is, accordingly, the translation of G∘@ (G on a particular address or path) into various alternative passages and profiles all provided by the unbound and generic relation of nature/gamespace to itself.

From a geometrical point of view, chimera is a bundle of different addresses or profiles for G∘@ or a particular composition within the topological space.

If snakes and ladders are merely self-addressed arrows and pointers highlighting passages in the continuous and self-relational environment of the gamespace/nature, then chimera can be defined as a non-trivial bundle of snakes and ladders. Or more precisely, chimera is a non-trivial bundle of snakes and ladders in which the reflection of the Goat into the abyss does not project, from a global perspective, the manifest image of the Goat but the topologically twisted chimera which is endowed with a canonical projection of the abyss over the Goat.

From a geometrical and topological perspective, chimera can therefore be denoted as:

$$\text{Snakes and Ladders} \longrightarrow \text{Nature/Abbyss/Gamespace} \xrightarrow{\textit{Chimera}} \text{Goat}$$

Within the geometric schema of the modern abyss, climbing any ladder or sliding over any snake toward or away from the Goat (by definition, a local composition) leads to a chimera, i.e. a Goat with a global twist.

As a post-pandemonic composition, chimera is already a musico-acoustical operator of vast analytico-synthetic powers capable of

i. Through decomposition techniques, functorial analyses and "modal ramifications"[12], unbinding the alternative profiles of a given composition (for example, topological equivalents, alternative functorial maps, modal variations, etc.) in a continuous environment and thereby, expanding its encyclopedic space.
ii. Subsequently, deforming, twisting and interweaving the aforesaid alternative profiles together in the most counterintuitively refined global structures which possess a limitless capacity for internal perturbations and further syntheses without succumbing to confusion.
iii. Incorporating, indexing and fusing with 'extraneous' entities through underlying continuities between various local fields (by means of different modes of descent into deep layers of the continuity of nature/abyss to itself), non-local modes of synthesis between incommensurable elements, tracing shared boundaries between different compositions, drawing topological equivalences, etc.

As the goat began frolicking around, climbing down and scrambling up vertiginous precipices, the chimera appeared less of a reflection and more of an opening, a concrete approach—composed of alternative paths, transits, knotted snakes and free-falling ladders

12 For modalization of a sign to its different local semiotic variations or sheaves see, Fernando Zalamea, Signos Triádicos. Lógica, Literatura, Artes. Nueve Cruces Latinoamericanos; and for diversifying a denotator (type) into alternative types and varying denotators by means of modal ramification see, Guerino Mazzola, The Topos of Music: Geometric Logic of Concepts, Theory, and Performance.

interwoven like a double-helix codifying the reflexivity of the chasm—toward nature's unbound relation to itself, one that could not be drawn unless the goat was first broken down and then reforged once again from the geometric and continuous perspective of the abyss staring into itself. 'To chimerize' now meant 'to turn—analytico-synthetically—a goat (a particular composition or local horizon such as that of Man) into a non-trivial perspective into the abyss, a new voice worthy of singing the "hymn to cliffs"[13]—that is, a post-pandemonic composition wherein ascension and descent of profound continuities bring out the most chimeric landscapes.

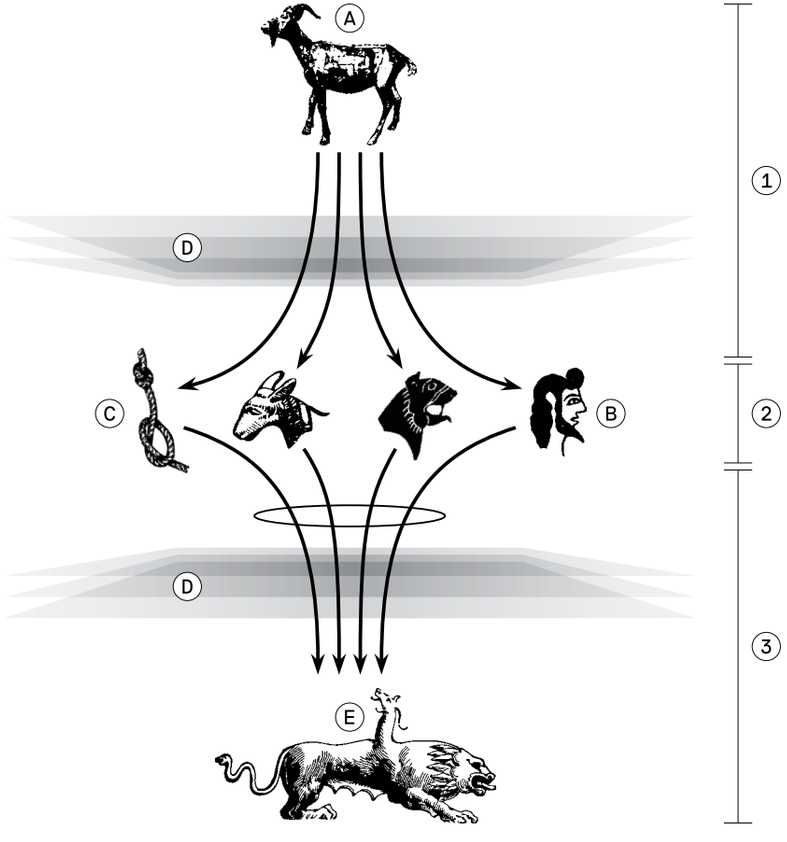


Figure 1. Chimerization (or the Goat's hymn to cliffs)
The goat's hymn to cliffs is comprised of (1) The ramification of the goat or a particular composition according to a layer of universal continuity (i.e. according to modal variations, different addresses and representational contexts that a particular layer of continuity provides); (2) broadening the goat's synthetic horizon by means of bringing into focus its alternative passages, different profiles, compositional variations and shifting boundaries (i.e. expanding the encyclopedic space of the goat); (3) re-bundling and synthesizing these alternatives and variations according to a more profound / universal layer of continuity which undergirds them. Therefore, the transition from goat to chimera—as an approach to nature's unbound relation to itself—involves climbing up and down between various edges, depths and borders of the modern abyss, simultaneously drawing borders of epistemic sheaves and deepening the ontological horizon.

(A) G∘@
(B) Non-Goat
(C) A Disenchanted Snake
(D) Different Layers of Continuity
(E) Chimera

13 Fernando Zalamea, América—Una Trama Integral: Transversalidad, Bordes y Abismos en la Cultura Americana.

HOW TO PLAY

A thesis on playing chimera: Since chimera unbinds a particular composition (G∘@) in terms of various compositions comprised of different objects and different paths opened through the continuous chimeric landscape and its topological neighborhoods, we can say:

– *The deeper the reflection of the Goat into the abyss, the broader the unfolding of alternative passages and compositional variations of the Goat.*

– *The broader alternative passages and compositional variations, the deeper and more detailed associations between them.*

– *The deeper and more detailed associations and connective maps between passages and compositions, the more opportunities for topological operations, gluings, deformations, transplantations and transfers of heterogeneous qualities … and the more twisted the chimera.*

In short, the greater the unbinding of a particular composition in terms of its continuous variations and alternative compositional addresses, the more freedom of choice and the more improvisational flexibility, i.e. a greater chimeric plasticity.